REPO RADAR

EffectCraft: a free motion graphics studio in Rust

Repo: github.com/storytold/effectcraft · License: MIT OR Apache-2.0 · by the ArtCraft team and EffectCraft contributors.

What it is

- An open-source compositor for animated titles, motion graphics and visual effects: compositions, layers, keyframes, a graph editor, expressions, 3D cameras and lights, and a render queue.
- 308 built-in effects (blur, color correction, distort, particles, glow, transitions...) and all nine layer styles.
- Video encoders written in pure Rust (H.264, ProRes, HEVC, VP9, AV1): **no FFmpeg inside**.
- Lottie import and export, readable JSON project files (`.ecproj`), and a headless CLI plus an MCP server for AI agents.
- First commit: 1 October 2026. Status: **alpha**. Its own parity document estimates about 91% of the tracked features exist, but only about 45% readiness for professional client work.

Install (build from source)

You need Rust 1.95 or newer (rustup.rs).

```
git clone https://github.com/storytold/effectcraft
cd effectcraft
cargo build --release -p effectcraft-cli
```

Then render the built-in demo, with no window and no GPU (headless renders run on the CPU):

```
./target/release/effectcraft-cli render --out intro.mp4
```

Prefer an installer? The project's Releases page lists builds for macOS, Windows, Linux (AppImage, Flatpak, deb, rpm), FreeBSD and the web.

3 things to try

1. **Open the desktop app with the demo:** `cargo run --release -p effectcraft -- --demo`
2. **Render one frame as a PNG:** `effectcraft-cli render-frame --time 3 --out frame.png`
3. **Let an AI agent drive it:** `effectcraft-cli mcp --demo` starts an MCP server (the repo ships a ready `.mcp.json`).

What we saw in our sandbox test

- Machine: 4-core cloud server, no graphics card, clean sandbox (no keys).
- Build: `cargo build --release -p effectcraft-cli` finished in 9 min 54 s (we turned off link-time optimisation to save time).
- Render: `effectcraft-cli render --out intro.mp4` wrote 300 frames of 1920×1080 H.264 (10 s of video) in 20.1 s, on the CPU.

Honest caveats

- Alpha software: the team says it is not yet recommended for production client work.
- macOS is the most tested platform; Linux and Windows users have reported basic interaction bugs.
- After Effects projects (`.aep`) cannot be opened.

Sources: the repository README, `docs/agents.md` and `docs/target-app-parity.md` (read on 12 November 2026).

Free guide from Repo Radar. Information only, not financial, legal or medical advice.